Institution: Metropolitan Museum of Art
Registration Number: 1989.281.69
Beazley Archive Number: 275024
Fabric: Attic earthenware, red-figure
Shape: Psykter
Attribution: Oltos, by Bothmer
Date: Archaic, c. 520-510 BCE
Dimensions: H. 30.20cm
Provenance: Gift of Norbert Schimmel Trust, 1989

Fabric, Technique, Shape & Condition Attic red-figure psykter, with a rounded body, narrow neck and flaring rim. Body of the vessel forms a mushroom-like figure. Figures rendered in reserve clay against a black-glazed ground. Relief contour lines and dilute glaze is used for interior modelling. Details added sparingly. The vessel has been restored with repair seams visible across the body. Missing decorative elements have been left unpainted but filled with colour-matched plaster. Surface shows minor wear and abrasion consistent with age.

Iconography Decorated with a repeating motif of six hoplites encircling the body of the vessel in a continuous frieze (Fig.1). Each figure is identically equipped with a Corinthian helmet, greaves, cuirass over a short chiton, shield, and spear. Each rider is accompanied by the inscription *epidelphinos* ("upon the dolphin").[1] The near-identical postures of the figures convey disciplined, rhythmic movement, reinforced by the even spacing of the figures around the surface of the vessel. Only the emblems on the shields distinguish individual figures: three have symposium vessels (krater, kantharos, cup), and the others carry various others (whirl with four dolphins, triskelis, whirl with the foreparts of a lion, horse, and griffin).

Fig. 1. Attributed to Oltos, Terracotta Psykter (Vase for Cooling Wine), ca. 520–510 BCE. Terracotta; red-figure, H. 11 7/8 in. (30.2 cm). Gift of Norbert Schimmel Trust, 1989. The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York, 1989.281.69.

Comparable vessels of this period depicting dolphin-riding figures include a flute player among the composition, which has led scholars to propose that such scenes illustrate a dramatic theatrical chorus (Fig. 2).[2] The absence of a flute player on this vessel complicates that reading, though the inscriptions and the rhythmic, processional character of the composition remains consistent with a performative or theatrical reference. The choice of subject is well suited for the vessel's function: as the psykter floated within a wine-filled krater, the dolphins would have appeared to leap and dive in and out of the surrounding liquid, animating the scene for guests of the symposia.

Attribution & Dating Attributed to Oltos (active approx. 525-500 BCE) by Bothmer.[3] Oltos was a prolific early red-

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[1] University of Basel. "Attic Vase Inscriptions (AVI)." Edited by Rudolf Wachter, based on Henry R. Immerwahr's Corpus of Attic Vase Inscriptions (CAVI). Record ID 4264. Accessed March 28, 2026. https://www.avi.unibas.ch/DB/searchform.html?ID=4264.

[2] Ibid.

[3] Classical Art Research Centre, University of Oxford. "Beazley Archive Pottery Database." Record 891DB12B-DA31-4766-A378-

figure painter known primarily as a cup painter, documented working for at least six different potters.[4]

Fig. 2. Heron Group, Drinking Cup (Skyphos) Depicting Chorus Scenes, Greek, Attic, ca. 500–490 BCE. Ceramic, black-figure. Side A: six warriors riding dolphins toward a flute player. Gift of the Heirs of Henry Adams. Museum of Fine Arts, Boston, 20.18.

Attribution relies on stylistic connoisseurship rather than signature, as his name appears on only two securely signed vessels.[5] The attribution of this psykter is supported by characteristic features of Oltos' draftsmanship: the precise, controlled detail and the rhythmic arrangement of the figural group around the surface of the vessel.[6]

The psykter as a vessel shape was produced only briefly, emerging in the late 6th century BCE and falling out of use by the early 5th century. The production window of the shape lasted from roughly 530 to 470 BCE. This narrow chronological range, combined with the stylistic evidence of the figural work and Oltos' known active period, supports a date of approximately 520-510 BCE.[7] The vessel represents the psykter form at the height of its production, when the shape attracted some of the most accomplished early red-figure painters, such as Euphronios and Douris alongside Oltos.[8]

E3CF9269BA5B (Vase no. 275024). Accessed March 10, 2026. https://www.beazley.ox.ac.uk/record/891DB12B-DA31-4766-A378-E3CF9269BA5B.

[4] J. Paul Getty Museum. "Oltos." Getty Collection, person record 103JPM. Accessed March 28, 2026. https://www.getty.edu/art/collection/person/103JPM; Böhr, Elke (Wiesbaden). "Oltos." In *Der Neue Pauly*. Leiden, Koninklijke Brill NV, October 1, 2006. https://doi.org/10.1163/1574-9347_dnp_e830060.

[5] Ibid.

[6] Ibid.

[7] Böhr, Elke (Wiesbaden). "Oltos." In Der Neue Pauly. Leiden, Koninklijke Brill NV, October 1, 2006. https://doi.org/10.1163/1574-9347_dnp_e830060; Classical Art Research Centre, University of Oxford. "Beazley Archive Pottery Database." Record 891DB12B-DA31-4766-A378-E3CF9269BA5B (Vase no. 275024). Accessed March 10, 2026.

[8] Scheibler, Ingeborg (Krefeld). "Psykter." In *Brill's New Pauly*. Leiden, Koninklijke Brill NV, October 1, 2006.

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